Discovering Tut: The Saga Continues

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1. Chapter Overview & Introduction

Discovering Tut: The Saga Continues by **A. R. Williams** is an illuminating, investigative account of the legendary Egyptian boy-king **Tutankhamun** (popularly known as King Tut). The article explores the dramatic discovery of his undisturbed tomb, the fabulous golden artifacts buried with him, the unfortunate physical damage inflicted upon his mummy by early archaeologists, and the modern deployment of cutting-edge computed tomography (CT scanning) to unravel the enduring mysteries surrounding his youthful life and unexpected death.

King Tut was the last heir of an immensely powerful royal family that had ruled Egypt's golden empire for centuries. He died mysteriously in his late teens, sparking widespread historical speculation—including theories of foul play and murder. On **5 January 2005**, precisely at 6:00 PM, King Tut's mummy was carefully removed from its subterranean tomb in the fabled **Valley of the Kings** to undergo a high-resolution CT scan aimed at shedding light on his exact age and cause of demise.

2. Howard Carter's Discovery & Forensic Complications (1922)

In 1922, British archaeologist **Howard Carter** discovered King Tut's underground tomb after years of fruitless excavations. Although grave robbers had ransacked parts of the antechambers in antiquity, the burial vault itself remained astonishingly intact. It housed the most spectacular hoard of royal gold treasures ever unearthed in archaeological history.

The royal burial complex revealed two categories of fascinating items:

- **Gold Artifacts of Resurrection:** Magnificent collars, necklaces, bracelets, rings, amulets, sandals, and a solid gold funerary mask and coffin designed to guarantee his eternal rebirth in the afterlife.
- **Everyday Comforts for Eternity:** Board games, a bronze razor, fine linen garments, dried fruits, food cases, and jars of wine intended for his comfort in the netherworld.

When Carter opened the outermost of the three nesting coffins, he found a shroud lovingly adorned with garlands of willow, olive leaves, wild celery, lotus petals, and cornflowers—botanical evidence establishing that the royal burial had occurred in **March or April**.

However, Carter encountered a catastrophic obstacle when reaching the innermost coffin: the ritual funerary resins had hardened into an unyielding cement, bonding the mummy rigidly to the solid gold base. Carter attempted to bake the coffin under blistering desert heat (reaching 149 degrees Fahrenheit), but the resin remained rock solid.

Fearing that leaving the gold in place would tempt thieves to rip the tomb apart under cover of darkness, Carter made the controversial decision to chisel away the hardened resin. His team severed the king's head and virtually all major limb joints to detach the mummy. They subsequently reassembled the

dismembered remains upon a bed of sand in a wooden box, which became Tut's modern resting place.

3. Evolution of Modern Archaeology & The 1968 X-Ray Revelation

In the decades following Carter's sensational find, the fundamental philosophy of archaeology transformed. The discipline shifted its primary focus away from sensational treasure-hunting toward forensic science, social anthropology, and reconstructing the daily realities and medical histories of ancient peoples.

In **1968**, more than forty years after Carter's excavations, an anatomy professor X-rayed the mummy and made a startling discovery: beneath the hardened chest resin, **King Tut's breastbone and front ribs were completely missing**. This revelation deepened the mystery: had the young king suffered a catastrophic chest trauma in battle, a chariot accident, or had he been assassinated?

To resolve these questions without further mutilating the fragile body, scientists turned to **Computed Tomography (CT)**. By capturing hundreds of cross-sectional X-ray slices, a CT scanner constructs a flawless 3D digital facsimile of the corpse, providing non-invasive forensic clarity.

4. Royal Dynasty, Religious Turmoil & Tut's Restoration

King Tut's lineage represents one of the most turbulent epochs in ancient Egyptian history:

- **Amenhotep III:** Tut's father or grandfather was a legendary pharaoh who ruled for nearly 40 prosperous years during the zenith of the 18th Dynasty.
- **Akhenaten's Heresy:** His eccentric successor, Amenhotep IV, initiated a radical religious upheaval. He outlawed traditional gods, elevated **Aten** (the sun disk), changed his own name to **Akhenaten** ('servant of the Aten'), and moved the royal capital from Thebes to the newly built city of **Akhetaten** (modern Amarna). Furthermore, he shocked the nation by smashing statues of the chief deity **Amun** and shutting down his ancient temples.
- **Tutankhaten to Tutankhamun:** Following Akhenaten's demise and the brief, mysterious reign of Smenkhkare, a young boy named **Tutankhaten** assumed the throne. Recognizing the country's spiritual distress, he swiftly restored traditional worship, changed his name to **Tutankhamun** ('living image of Amun'), and oversaw an orderly return to the old religion. He reigned for roughly nine years before passing away unexpectedly.

5. The High-Tech CT Scan of January 5, 2005

Under the auspices of the **Egyptian Mummy Project** (which had recorded over 600 mummies since late 2003), King Tut's mummy was selected to become the first to undergo scanning using a portable state-of-the-art CT machine manufactured by **Siemens** and donated by the **National Geographic Society**.

On the cold desert night of **5 January 2005**, ghostly dust devils swirled as Tut's mummy was hoisted out of the tomb into a customized scanning trailer. The apparatus recorded **1,700 digital cross-sectional X-ray images** from head to toe. Tut's skull was scanned in microscopic **0.62-millimetre slices** to

capture the finest structural nuances.

A dramatic technical hitch occurred when desert sand blew into the scanner's cooling fans, causing the machine to stall. A nervous guard whispered, *'Curse of the Pharaoh!'* However, technicians quickly brought out two white replacement fans, allowing the scan to resume. In less than three hours, the mummy was returned peacefully to his underground crypt beneath the Valley of the Kings. **Zahi Hawass**, Secretary General of Egypt's Supreme Council of Antiquities, breathed a profound sigh of relief that no further damage had occurred.

KEY EXAMINATION TAKEAWAYS & CRITICAL ANALYSIS

- **Central Theme:** Demonstrates the marriage of modern medical technology (CT scanning) and forensic archaeology in solving ancient historical enigmas without invasive physical destruction.
- **Howard Carter's Justification vs Critique:** Carter's chiselling defended as necessary to prevent thievery, yet criticized for irreversibly damaging the anatomical integrity of the mummy.
- **Significance of Akhenaten's Reign:** Marked a fanatic monotheistic disruption of Egyptian traditions; King Tut's historical acclaim rests largely upon his restoration of Amun worship.
- **The Curse of the Pharaoh:** Popularized folklore that disturbing royal tombs brings misfortune; scientifically demystified during the 2005 scan despite the eerie dust storm and fan malfunction.